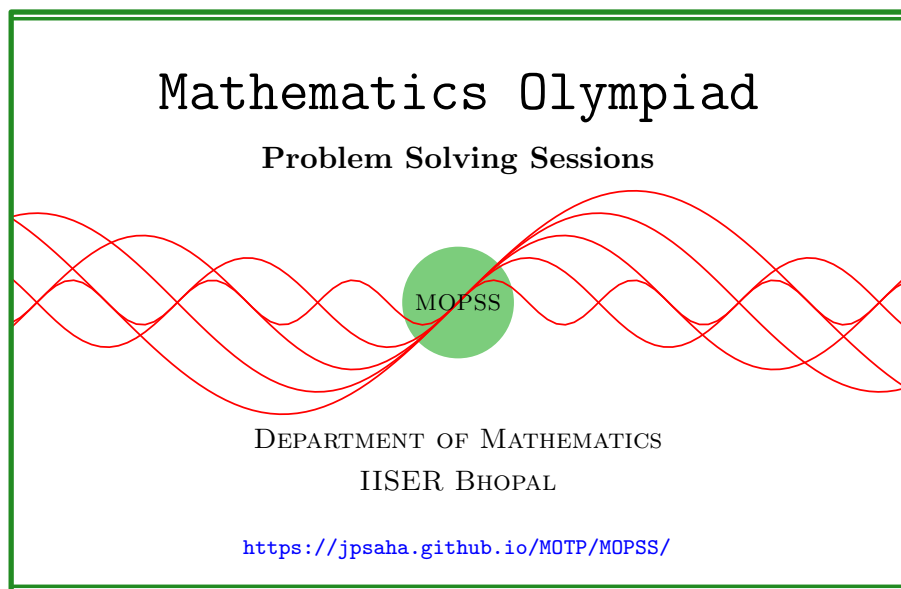


Crossing the x -axis

MOPSS



Suggested readings

- Evan Chen's advice [On reading solutions](https://blog.evanchen.cc/2017/03/06/on-reading-solutions/), available at <https://blog.evanchen.cc/2017/03/06/on-reading-solutions/>.
- Evan Chen's [Advice for writing proofs/Remarks on English](https://web.evanchen.cc/handouts/english/english.pdf), available at <https://web.evanchen.cc/handouts/english/english.pdf>.
- [Notes on proofs](#) by Evan Chen from [OTIS Excerpts](#) [[Che25](#), Chapter 1].
- [Tips for writing up solutions](https://www.math.utoronto.ca/barbeau/writingup.pdf) by Edward Barbeau, available at <https://www.math.utoronto.ca/barbeau/writingup.pdf>.
- Evan Chen discusses why [math olympiads](#) are a valuable experience for [high schoolers](#) in the post on [Lessons from math olympiads](#), available at <https://blog.evanchen.cc/2018/01/05/lessons-from-math-olympiads/>.

List of problems and examples

1.1	Example	2
1.2	Example	2
1.3	Example	2
1.4	Example	3
1.5	Exercise (China TST 1995 Day 2 P2, AoPS)	3

§1 Crossing the x -axis

Here are a few problems from [this notes](#), and [this one](#).

Example 1.1. Suppose $P(x)$ is a polynomial with real coefficients such that $P(x) = x$ has no real solution. Show that $P(P(x)) = x$ has no real solutions.

Walkthrough —
(a)

Solution 1. Since $x \mapsto P(x)$ defines a continuous map from $\mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, by the intermediate value theorem, it follows that $P(x) > x$ holds for all $x \in \mathbb{R}$ or $P(x) < x$ holds for all $x \in \mathbb{R}$. If $P(x) > x$ holds for all $x \in \mathbb{R}$, then $P(P(x)) > P(x) > x$ holds for all $x \in \mathbb{R}$, and hence $P(P(x)) = x$ has no real solutions. Similarly, if $P(x) < x$ holds for all $x \in \mathbb{R}$, then $P(P(x)) = x$ has no real solutions. ■

Example 1.2. Any polynomial of odd degree with real coefficients has a real root.

Example 1.3. Let $P(x)$ and $Q(x)$ be monic polynomials of degree 10 having real coefficients. Assume that the equation $P(x) = Q(x)$ has no real roots. Prove that the equation $P(x + 1) = Q(x - 1)$ has at least one real root.

Walkthrough —
(a) Consider the difference $P(x) - Q(x)$ to show that the coefficient of x^9 in these polynomials are equal.
(b) Prove that the polynomial $P(x + 1) - Q(x - 1)$ is of degree 9.

Solution 2. Note that $P(x) - Q(x)$ is a polynomial of degree at most 9 having real coefficients. Since $P(x) - Q(x)$ has no real root, it follows that it has degree at most 8. In other words, the coefficients of x^9 in $P(x), Q(x)$ are the same. Note that $P(x + 1) - Q(x - 1)$ is of degree ≤ 9 , and the coefficient of x^9 in $P(x + 1) - Q(x - 1)$ is equal to the coefficient of x^9 in $(x + 1)^{10} - (x - 1)^{10}$,

which is equal to 20. This shows that $P(x+1) - Q(x-1)$ is a polynomial of degree 9 with real coefficients. Consequently, it has at least one real root. ■

Example 1.4. Let $P(x)$ be a nonconstant polynomial with real coefficients having a real root. Suppose it does not vanish at 0. Show that the monomial terms appearing in $P(x)$ can be erased one by one to obtain its constant term such that the intermediate polynomials have at least one real root.

Walkthrough —

(a)

Solution 3. Write $P(x) = a_n x^n + \cdots + a_0$ with $a_n, \dots, a_0$ lying in $\mathbb{R}$, and $a_n a_0 \neq 0$. Since any polynomial of odd degree has a real root, it follows that if the degree of $P(x)$ is odd, then the nonconstant monomials, other than the leading term, can be erased one by one, and then, the leading term can be erased to obtain a_0 , and the intermediate polynomials have a real root. If a_n, a_0 are of opposite signs and n is even, then the same process can be followed, and note that any of the intermediate polynomials takes values of opposite signs at 0 and at a large enough integer, and hence has a real root.

Let us assume that n is even, and a_n, a_0 are of the same sign. Let α denote a real root of $P(x)$. Let $Q(x)$ denote the polynomial $P(x) - a_n x^n$. Note that $Q(0) = a_0$ and $Q(\alpha) = -a_n \alpha^n$. Since a_0 is nonzero, it follows that $\alpha \neq 0$, and hence, $Q(0), Q(\alpha)$ are of opposite signs. This shows that $Q(x)$ is a nonconstant polynomial with real coefficients having a real root, and it does not vanish at 0. Since the degree of $Q(x)$ is smaller than that of $P(x)$, by induction, we are done. ■

Exercise 1.5 (China TST 1995 Day 2 P2, AoPS). Alice and Bob play a game with a polynomial of degree at least 4:

$$x^{2n} + \square x^{2n-1} + \square x^{2n-2} + \cdots + \square x + 1.$$

They take turns to fill the empty boxes. If the resulting polynomial has no real root, Alice wins, otherwise, Bob wins. If Alice goes first, who has a winning strategy?

Walkthrough —

- (a) There are more odds than evens among the integers $1, 2, \dots, 2n-1$.
- (b) Can Bob have a winning strategy using the odds in his favour?

Solution 4. Bob has a winning strategy, as described below.

Bob makes sure that at the end of each of his turns except the last one, the number of even powers of x whose coefficients have been provided by some of

them is equal to the number of odd powers of x whose coefficients have been provided by some of them. This can be done, for instance, if during a turn of Bob, other than the last turn, Bob provides the coefficient of an odd (resp. even) power of x if Alice has provided the coefficient of an even (resp. odd) power of x in the preceeding turn.

Since $n \geq 2$, it follows that Bob gets at least one turn. At the beginning of the final turn of Bob, there are two powers of x whose coefficients are to be determined, denote them by x^i, x^j , their coefficients by c_i, c_j respectively. Let $Q(x)$ denote the polynomial, obtained by the erasing the terms corresponding to x^i, x^j from the polynomial that Bob had at the beginning of his final turn. Note that

$$P(x) = Q(x) + c_i x^i + c_j x^j.$$

Note that at least of i, j is odd. Interchanging i, j if necessary, let us assume that i is odd. We describe the strategy that Bob follows in the two cases below.

Let us consider the case that j is even. Bob determines c_j in such a way that for any choice of c_i , the completed polynomial $P(x)$ is guaranteed to have at least one real root. This can be done, for instance, by taking c_j satisfying

$$Q(1) + Q(-1) + 2c_j = 0.$$

For any choice of c_i , the above choice of c_j shows that $P(1) + P(-1) = 0$, which implies that $P(x)$ has a root in the interval $[-1, 1]$.

Let us consider the case that j is odd. Bob determines c_j in such a way that for any choice of c_i by Alice in the next turn, the completed polynomial $P(x)$ is guaranteed to have at least one real root. This can be done, for instance, by taking c_j satisfying

$$Q(2) + c_j 2^j + 2^i Q(-1) - c_j 2^i = 0.$$

Since $i \neq j$, the above holds for some $c_j \in \mathbb{R}$. For any choice of c_i , note that

$$P(2) + 2^i P(-1) = 0$$

holds, which implies that $P(x)$ has a root in $[-1, 2]$. ■

References

- [Che25] EVAN CHEN. *The OTIS Excerpts*. Available at <https://web.evanchen.cc/excerpts.html>. 2025, pp. vi+289 (cited p. 1)